

Non-Wood Forest Products of Bhutan

LEGAL STATUS OF NWFPs in BHUTAN

Forest Policy, 2011

Bhutan's forest policy places conservation above all other considerations. Harvesting or commercial use of the forest is only permitted after conservation goals have been met and only if management policies ensure sustainable use.

PROBLEMS AND CONSTRAINTS IN DEVELOPING NON-WOOD FOREST PRODUCTS

- ❖ Bhutan's potential for developing its non-wood forest products (NWFP) is quite considerable. But this promising sector is burdened, at least for the present, by several serious constraints. Too little is known, for instance, about the country's existing resources, management strategies, best harvesting practices and marketing opportunities. Professionals in the NWFP sector are far too few and they have limited knowledge of practical management and prospects for further and future development. Institutional support is extremely weak.
- ❖ There is an acute lack of inventory data and even many of the best informed Bhutanese professionals admit they are all but completely in the dark as to the country's real NWFP resources. But finding out just what these resources are and, equally important, where they are requires money, and money is precisely the resource in shortest supply in the country. Bhutan is, after all, one of the poorest countries on earth. Per capita income is a lowly US\$150 a year and government financial resources are never adequate to cover Bhutan's almost endless development needs.
- ❖ The shortage of quality training institutes in the country is another major constraint to Bhutanese development. Legal codes and laws governing most phases of forestry development are as yet inadequate and where they do exist they are all too often ignored. Comprehensive enforcement of modern forestry legislation, even were it to exist, would require more forestry officers than Bhutan could afford to put into the field.
- ❖ Geography itself is a massive physical barrier to the country's rapid development. Bhutan lies in the heart of the beautiful but stupendously rugged Eastern Himalayas, and is, in fact, one of the most mountainous countries on the planet. To build a good all-weather road in Bhutan is a colossal and extremely expensive achievement. The present road network, for instance, though by far the best the country has ever known, makes the transport of goods a slow, costly and at times dangerous endeavor. Roads, uniformly narrow due to the Himalayan peaks through which they pass, are few and far between.
- ❖ During the long rainy season and the winters of ice and snow, Bhutan's roads often become altogether impassable, beset as they are by landslides and washouts. All this adds up to far more than just human inconvenience. It is a major obstacle to development of any kind.

- ❖ These problems and developmental constraints seriously affect every aspect of the country's social and economic advancement, including its budding non-wood forest products industry

GENERAL RECOMMENDATIONS FOR LONG-TERM ACTIVITIES IN DEVELOPING NON-WOOD FOREST PRODUCTS

- Establish national priorities based on all known non-wood forest products and prioritise them according to an agreed set of criteria.
- Aim for a more complete inventory of the prioritised commodities, giving species, locations, and quantities. This would involve taxonomists, botanists, forest rangers, and foresters, among others.
- Train personnel in plant identification, proper collection methods, appropriate processing techniques, efficient manufacturing procedures, quality control, and the generation of new designs.
- Establish and maintain gene banks for conservation, tissue culture, and seed storage, and start a collection of voucher herbarium specimens; set up extension and information centres for teaching the art of vegetable dyeing.
- Set up post-harvest handling facilities as close to commodity sources as possible for drying, sifting, deep freezing, controlled atmosphere, etc.
- Initiate annual scholarships and grants for B.Sc., M.Sc., and Ph.D. degrees in related disciplines or short-term, non-degree training programmes for acquiring new technologies.
- Create an agency, or agencies, to serve as the national clearing house for all matters pertaining to non-wood forest products, including marketing. This should include a mechanism to oversee annual reviews of accomplishments, preferably conducted by unbiased third-party personnel

The use and management of NWFPs in Bhutan are primarily governed by the Forest and Nature Conservation Act of Bhutan 2023

The concerned DFOs and Park Offices are responsible for facilitating NWFP allocation and utilization and assisting community-based forest enterprise establishment through planning and monitoring of operations while Forest Resource Planning & Management Division (FRPMD) oversees NWFP management and provide technical support for the preparation and implementation of NWFP plans

Under the Conservation Act, all NWFP harvesting activities must be formally integrated into either PA, Community Forest Management Plans (CFMPs) or FMU plans, in compliance with the technical guidelines provided by DoFPS. Despite the potential of NWFPs to contribute to rural

livelihoods and green economic development, their current use in Bhutan remains largely at subsistence levels, with minimal commercialization.

Today, the *Cordyceps sinensis* represents the most economically significant NWFP in Bhutan, accounting for the bulk of NWFP revenue, despite the diverse variety of NWFP available in the country

Moreover, monetization opportunities from other forest resources, such as NWFPs, are constrained by:

- a. fragmented value chains
- b. lack of processing facilities, and
- c. absence of product certification or quality assurance standards for downstream value addition

Bhutan's NWFP exports remain limited in both scale and scope due to a lack of value-added processing infrastructure, underdeveloped market access and value chains, capability gaps among NWFP enterprises, and an unreliable supply of raw materials.

Despite the growing interest in NWFPs as a means of rural livelihood enhancement, several challenges continue to hinder their commercialization in Bhutan

- A major constraint is the limited processing for value addition, with most NWFPs such as bamboo and mushrooms being sold in raw form at local markets or auction yards, without any branding or processing.
 - This is compounded by limited market access, largely due to the absence of product certification mechanisms, which makes it difficult for producers to tap into premium markets or meet export standards.
 - Additionally, NWFP enterprises often lack technical, financial, and digital capabilities, including essential skills in business management, packaging, and value-added production.
 - The sector also struggles with limited scalability, as raw material supply is typically unreliable – driven by seasonal availability and weather fluctuations – making it difficult to establish consistent, large-scale operations.